the Palestinian Authority or to Gaza." He warned repeatedly that the Zionist Camp was looking to form a government with "the Arabs".

"In the last three months, he's been worse than Lieberman," Ahmad Tibi, the head of the secular Ta'al party, told me at a rally in Jaffa on the eve of the vote. "We're talking about a prime minister here. It's hard to believe. For the first time, a prime minister is telling his citizens to leave the state."

In this fraught climate, Odeh was managing to appeal to Jews as well, saying he hoped to win at least one seat's worth of votes from them. He cultivated a mild-mannered, friendly image, and avoided controversial issues. Asked about Hamas, for example, he stressed the need for Palestinian unity, asking why, "Sixty-six years after the *nakba*, we're still divided between Hamas and Fatah." He also chose to focus on the economy, an issue that resonates with everyone, and about equality, often citing Martin Luther King Jr in speeches (a photo of King would later hang in his Knesset office). He released a kitschy but well-received campaign video that showed him winning over voters at a Shabbat lunch in Tel Aviv. When Amos Biderman, the *Ha'aretz* cartoonist, drew a caricature of the candidates dressed in costume for Purim—the Israeli equivalent of Halloween—Odeh was Mickey Mouse.

Many Jewish Israelis, perhaps a bit patronizingly, described him as likable, surprising, "the guy next door." They contrasted him with outspoken Arab parliamentarians like Tibi and Hanin Zoabi, the latter of whom was suspended from the Knesset in 2014 because she refused to describe the kidnapping and murder of three Jewish teenagers in the West Bank as "terrorism". Judy Shalom Nir-Mozes, the wife of a Likud minister, fretted that Odeh was "a very dangerous person in my eyes, because he conveys a message to which you can connect as an Israeli."

Historically, Arab parties have refused to sit in the government, arguing that they cannot join a Zionist cabinet, cannot be responsible for settlement construction or another war in Gaza. "Every Israeli government, from Buji (the nickname for Herzog) to Bibi, they're all the same thing," said Abdullah Abu Ma'arouf, a Joint List candidate. The most they would do, Odeh and others said, would be to provide backing from outside the government. There was historical precedent for this. After then-Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin had signed the Oslo Accords in 1993, support from the Arab parties allowed him to survive a no-confidence motion.